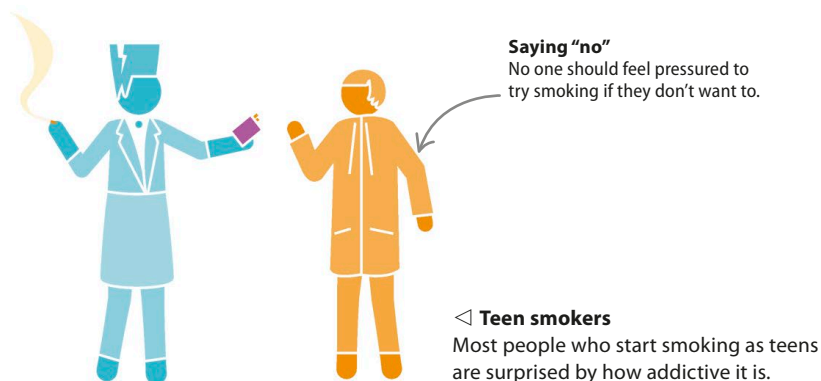


Smoking

Smoking cigarettes releases nicotine into the bloodstream. This chemical alters brain chemistry, causing relaxation, but in the long term it's highly addictive. Smoking releases other harmful substances into the body that damage organs and overall health.

Teen smokers

Some teens start smoking because they feel pressured to do so by their friends, while others smoke to feel independent, even though they know the risks. Teen smokers have poorer fitness than nonsmokers due to the build-up of tobacco residue, or "tar," which reduces heart and lung function, as well as causing tooth and gum decay. Smokers also have a higher risk of cancer and are more likely to develop type 2 diabetes. One in two people who smoke will die from a smoking-related disease.



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MYTH BUSTER

The truth about smoking

It doesn't look cool. It also comes with bad breath, stinky hair, and a reduced sense of taste.

It won't help you fit in. Never feel that you have to do something dangerous to fit in with people you call friends.

You won't just be able to have one or two. Research suggests that the brains of young people are more vulnerable to nicotine addiction than adults, so even one or two is enough to develop an addiction.

Nicotine addiction

It's difficult for smokers to stop smoking, even if they want to quit, because cigarettes contain nicotine, an addictive chemical. Nicotine alters the balance of two hormones, dopamine and norepinephrine, in the brain. These hormones produce feelings of pleasure and reduce anxiety and stress. When a smoker does quit, nicotine cravings can cause stress, depression, and irritability.

GOOD TO KNOW

E-cigarettes

E-cigarettes (also known as vapes) are designed to be used by people who want to give up smoking. They contain nicotine, but are much safer because there's no smoke or tar. However, they are not completely harmless, and are just as addictive as regular cigarettes.

▽ Cigarettes

Nicotine causes addiction, but it's not the most harmful chemical in cigarettes. The smoke from just one cigarette contains more than 4,000 harmful chemicals, including carbon monoxide and tar.

